

Session 31: The Meaning of Three Days and Three Nights

Key Takeaways

- “Three days,” the time Jonah was in the belly of the fish, was a common phrase that conveyed the idea of a dangerous, ominous journey that brought someone near to death.

A Fishy Womb?

In [Jonah 2:1](#), the word “fish” is a masculine noun, *dag* (דג), but in [2:2](#), “from the belly of the fish,” unexpectedly uses a feminine noun, *dagah* (דגה).

“Interpreters have noted that the Hebrew term for ‘the fish’ changes from the masculine form *haddāg* in verse 1 to the feminine form *haddāgā* in verse 2 [nrsv: 1]. Although this shift remains problematic, Jonah’s presence in the belly of the fish suggests the imagery of pregnancy for the fish and new birth or new creation for Jonah.”

Sweeney, Marvin A. (2000). [Berit Olam: Studies in Hebrew Narrative and Poetry: The Twelve Prophets](#). Liturgical Press. 317.

“[T]he male fish (*dag*) that devoured Jonah in 2:1 becomes a female (*dagah*) for Jonah once he enters her entrails. The point is forced upon us further as we hear Jonah, from the belly of a female fish, sing a misguided song from the womb of Sheol.”

Ackerman, James (1981). “Satire and Symbolism in the Song of Jonah.” [Traditions in Transformation: Turning Points in Biblical Faith](#). Eisenbrauns. 235-256.

Three Days and Three Nights

The landmark study on this phrase was made by George Landes in “The Three Days and Three Nights Motif in Jonah 2:1” from the *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86 (1967), pages 446-450.

Within the Hebrew Bible, the time span of “three days and nights” or arriving somewhere “on the third day” appears in two main connections.

A Time of Testing, Danger, or Near-Death

This phrase is often used to signify a period of testing or danger that brings someone near death.

1 Samuel 30:12b NASB

For he had not eaten bread or drunk water for three days and three nights.

2 Kings 20:5, 8 NASB

⁵ Return and say to Hezekiah the leader of my people, "This is what the LORD, the God of your father David says: 'I have heard your prayer, I have seen your tears; behold, I am going to heal you. On the third day you shall go up to the house of the LORD.'" ... ⁸ Now Hezekiah said to Isaiah, "What will be the sign that the LORD will heal me, and that I will go up to the house of the LORD on the third day?"

Hosea 6:1-2 NASB

¹ Come, let's return to the LORD.
For he has torn us, but he will heal us;
he has wounded us, but he will bandage us.
² He will revive us after two days;
he will raise us up on the third day,
that we may live before him.

"In each case, the time period is specified not to imply the still present possibility of a deliverance but to emphasize the comparative duration of the affliction under the circumstances."

Landes, George (1967). ["The 'Three Days and Three Nights' Motif in Jonah 2:1."](#) *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86. 448.

An Ominous Journey

"Three days" is also used in the Bible to signal an ominous or challenging journey.

- The Israelites' journey from Egypt through the waters to Mount Sinai was to take three days ([Exod. 3:18, 5:3, 8:27, 15:22](#)).
- The first three-day journey in the Bible is Abraham's journey to Jerusalem to sacrifice Isaac ([Gen. 22:4](#)).
- See also [Joshua 2:16, 9:17](#); [1 Samuel 30:1](#); [2 Samuel 20:4](#); [2 Kings 2:17](#).

The most ancient appearance of the phrase "three days and three nights" is in a Sumerian (ca. 1800 B.C.E.) mythological text, where the goddess descends into the underworld of death to visit her recently dead sister Ereshkigal. The time of her "virtual death" is described as three days and three nights.

"The three days and three nights are intended to cover the time of Inanna's travel to the depths of the underworld ... This appears to be a most promising clue for understanding the full import of this phrase to ancient near eastern scribes and readers, including the author of Jonah. In Jonah 2:1 the phrase indicates the period of time it took the fish to bring Jonah back from the Deep, understood more explicitly in the following poem as the netherworld ([2:2](#) 'from the belly of Sheol') ... Jonah's residence in the fish is therefore not the same thing as being in the Deep or in Sheol, and the fish is not employed as a personification of the chaotic waters or the realm of the dead. It is clearly before Jonah is swallowed by the fish that he is threatened by the sea and in danger of permanent residence in the nether world."

Landes, George (1967). "The 'Three Days and Three Nights' Motif in Jonah 2:1." *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86. 448.

Hosea chapters 5 and 6 are also relevant to our understanding of "three days" in the Hebrew Bible.

Hosea 5:13-15 NASB*

¹³ When Ephraim saw his sickness,
and Judah his wound,
then Ephraim went to Assyria
and sent to the great king.
But he is unable to heal you,
or to cure you of your wound.

¹⁴ For I am like a lion to Ephraim
and like a young lion to the house of Judah.
I, even I, will tear to pieces and go away,
I will carry away, and there will be none to deliver.

¹⁵ I will go away and return to my place
until they acknowledge their guilt and seek my face;
in their distress (לו בצר) they will earnestly seek me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Hosea 6:1-3 NASB

¹ Come, let us return to the LORD.
For he has torn us, but he will heal us;
he has wounded us, but he will bandage us.
² He will bring us life after two days;
he will raise us up on the third day,
that we may have life in his presence.
³ So let us know, let us press on to know the LORD.
His going forth is as certain as the dawn;
and he will come to us like the rain,
like the spring rain watering the earth.

Notice that in Hosea 5-6 and in Jonah 2, Yahweh is the one controlling a terrifying animal (lion/great fish). And while being devoured by this animal would be certain death in normal circumstances, with the creator of life, apparent death can become a strange vehicle for humbling leading to new life.

Jesus draws on this network of "three day" passages when he uses the phrase "three days" or "on the third day" to describe his liberation from death into resurrection life (Matt. 12:40, 16:21; Luke 24:21, 46).

Reflection Question

What's the significance of Jonah being in the fish for three days and three nights? What are we supposed to understand?